Liminal Multiverse: Class Showcase Design Documentation

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Overview

I connected the whole class's work into **one GitHub repository and one website**: 15 students, 15 planets, one link to share, each planet opening that student's live project. That connection is the heart of this redesign.

The original site and its visual world were designed by **Medha Halapnavar**. I kept her atmosphere (iridescent planets, orbital rings, the observer figures, the Observatory 2050 framing) and redesigned the structure around it: how projects are stored, how visitors find and open them, and how classmates add their own work without touching code.

The result has two ways in. The **3D View** keeps the immersive multiverse. The **List View** shows the same 15 projects as a calm, animation-free list. Both share one header, one category filter and one numbering system.

The big idea: every project, one repository, one site

Before this, each student's project lived on its own site with its own link, shared one by one. To see a classmate's work you had to ask for it. Now one repository feeds one website, and that website leads to every project in the class.

The class already kept each student's work in its own folder of a shared repository (arko97x/not-localhost-showcase). The showcase builds on that: one shared `class deployment` folder holds the site and one small file per student, and those files *are* the showcase.

Why this matters:

- **One front door.** A single link presents the whole class: for crits, portfolios, open days, or a tutor reviewing everyone's work. Nobody hunts through chats for 15 URLs.
- **One source of truth.** A student's link, project name and description live in exactly one place, their own file. Change it once and the planet, the list, the hover card and the bottom bar all update together.
- **Students own their entry.** Each student updates their own file, in the browser, whenever their project changes. Nobody waits on the person who built the site.

- **Safe by default.** GitHub records every change, so a mistake can be seen and undone. Edits from students without access arrive as requests that are checked before going live.
- **Equal presentation.** Every project gets the same planet, the same card and the same place in the list, so the showcase is about the work, not about who had time to build a nicer page.
- **Grows without a rebuild.** A new student is a new file. The site finds it, numbers it and gives it a planet automatically.

Starting point: Medha's original

Medha's site was a rich, single-story experience built in Google AI Studio (React, Vite and Three.js). It showcased 13 fictional speculative-design projects, such as Omni-Retina and Synthetic Ghosts, all written into one 1,340-line data file.

What a visitor got:

- **A 3D multiverse** of 13 planets, each with rings, satellites and a hooded observer figure standing on top.
- **A full-screen "world dossier"** on every click: a 3D wizard avatar that read a three-part monologue aloud, a manifesto, a patent-style speculative technology, an interactive simulation, artifacts and an "intercepted transmission".
- **Constant sound**: synthesized ambient space audio, hover pings, warp sounds and chimes.
- **"+ Transmit World"**, a form to invent new planets in the browser.

It was a strong piece of world-building, but it was built to show *one* author's invented projects. A class showcase needs the opposite: real projects by 15 people, each leading somewhere else, easy to update and easy to browse.

Goals and design principles

The redesign had one job: get a visitor from "what is this?" to a classmate's project in as few steps as possible, without losing the world Medha built.

1. **The planet is the doorway, not the destination.** Each student's real work lives on their own site, so clicking a planet should take you there, not to an invented dossier.
2. **Readable at a glance.** You should know which planet is which without hovering: a number and a project name on every planet.
3. **Motion is a choice.** The 3D view is the experience, but anyone who finds it disorienting, slow or inaccessible gets a full, equal alternative.

4. **One system, two views.** Same header, same switcher position, same filter, same numbers in both views, so switching never feels like a different site.
5. **Content without code.** A classmate with no technical background should be able to add their project by editing one small file in the browser.
6. **Keep the atmosphere.** Colours, typography, planets and the Observatory 2050 framing stay; clutter and jargon go.

What I changed, why, and how

Nine design decisions, in the order I made them. Each one solved a problem a visitor or a classmate would hit.

1. One file per student

- **Problem:** all project content sat in one 1,340-line code file. Adding a project meant editing code and risking the whole site.
- **Decision:** every project gets its own small JSON file, named after its student (e.g. `ishita-sarin.json`).
- **How:** the site now loads every file in the `projects` folder automatically. Drop in a new file and a new planet appears; no code changes.

2. Removing all audio

- **Problem:** ambient sound, hover pings, warp effects and a talking wizard started on their own. In a classroom, on a phone or in a gallery, uninvited sound is the fastest way to make someone close a tab.
- **Decision:** the showcase is silent. Students' own projects can bring their own sound.
- **How:** removed the sound engine, every sound effect, the text-to-speech voice and the buttons that controlled them. All the written text stayed.

3. Planets link straight to projects

- **Problem:** clicking a planet opened a huge dossier of invented content. For a class showcase that's a dead end between the visitor and the real work.
- **Decision:** a planet is a doorway. One click opens that student's project in a **new tab**, so the multiverse stays open behind it.
- **How:** each file has a `url` field. With no link yet, the planet says "Link coming soon" instead of failing silently. I removed the dossier page, the 3D wizard and all the dummy content only it used, which cut each file from about 95 lines to 56.

4. Numbers and names on the planets

- **Problem:** planets were anonymous until you hovered, and there's no hover on a phone.
- **Decision:** every planet carries its number and project name.
- **How:** I iterated on placement three times: under the planet (it fought with the rings), above it (it fought with the observer figure), and finally **on the planet's face**. The label always turns to face the viewer, sits on a soft dark backdrop so it reads over bright colours, and wraps long names onto up to three lines.

5. List View, for people who don't want 3D

- **Problem:** 3D orbit, zoom and constant motion exclude people with motion sensitivity, older devices, screen readers or simply no patience.
- **Decision:** a full alternative, not a fallback: every project, number, name, category and link in a plain list.
- **How:** the 3D scene shuts down completely in List View, so nothing moves and the page is light. Visitors whose device is set to "reduce motion" land on List View automatically, and `#index` in the address opens it directly.

6. A hint that points the way

- **Problem:** an alternative nobody notices doesn't help.
- **Decision:** on first visit, a popup asks "Don't want the 3D view?" and points at the List View button.
- **How:** a notch and an arrow aim at the button, which glows while the hint is open. Closing it (or pressing Esc) hides it for good for that visitor.

7. Making it one cohesive site

A review as a first-time visitor found five problems. I fixed all of them:

- **The hover card was unclickable.** It vanished the moment you moved off the planet. It now lingers briefly so you can reach its link.
- **The views felt like two sites.** A single **3D View | List View** switch now sits in the same place on both, under the same header.
- **The filter and numbers didn't match.** The category filter now exists in both views and carries over when you switch; numbers read 1, 2, 3 everywhere.
- **Jargon and clutter.** Labels like "Desktop Observatory", "Worlds Anchored" and "SPHERE-01 // …" became plain instructions: "15 projects · Drag to rotate · Click a planet to open it". Phones get their own wording.
- **A trap.** "+ Transmit World" let visitors create planets that vanished on refresh. Removed: projects now come only from the students' files.

Hovering a name in the bottom bar now also highlights its planet and opens its card, tying the list to the 3D world.

8. A hover card in each planet's colours

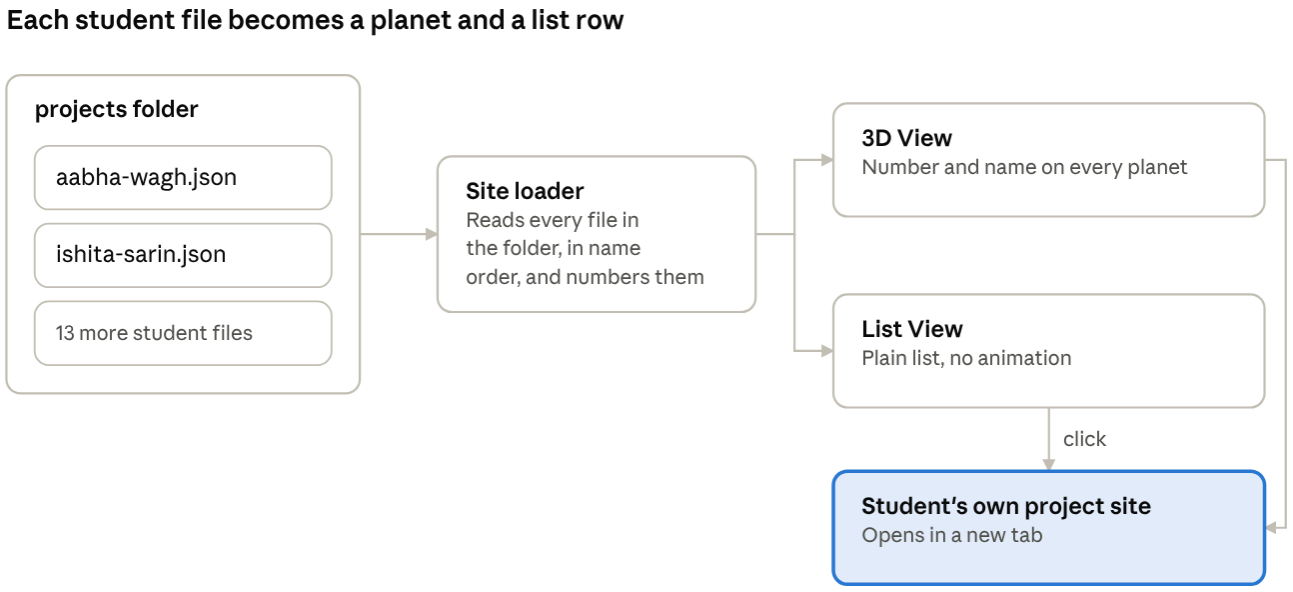
- **Problem:** every hover card looked identical, so moving between planets didn't register.
- **Decision:** the card takes on the colours of the planet you're on.
- **How:** border, glow, background gradient, top stripe, number badge, category tag and link all use that planet's colours, and the card fades in fresh on each change. Dark colours like deep purple are lightened for text so they stay readable.

9. Getting the site to run

- **Problem:** the original needed newer tools than the machine had, and failed to start.
- **How:** I ran it with a newer version of Node through a one-line command instead of changing the computer's setup, and wrote that command into the instructions.

Connecting the class projects

The site now has 15 planets, one per student, and adding a sixteenth means adding one file.



how a student's file reaches the site · 4 steps

Each student's file feeds both views at once. Planets are numbered by alphabetical file name (1 = Aabha Wagh, 15 = Urvi Khadakban), and the same number appears on the planet, in the bottom bar, on the hover card and in List View.

Only a few lines in each file appear on the site. Everything else controls the planet's look, so students are asked to leave it alone.

Field	What it changes on the site	Who edits it
`url`	Where clicking the planet or list row goes	Student
`subtitle`	Project name, written on the planet and as the list heading	Student
`quote`	One-line description on the hover card	Student
`name`	Student's name in the bottom bar, card and list	Student
`avatarRune`	Emoji next to the name	Student
`sector`	Category used by the filter (one of three)	Student
`year`	Year shown on the card and in the list	Student
`themeColor`, `sphere`	Planet colours, size, position and rings	Organiser
`id`	Internal name; must match the file	Nobody

The first 13 students inherited Medha's original planet designs; the last two got new pink and blue palettes, placed at least 15 units from any other planet so nothing overlaps.

Making it live

The showcase lives in its own shared folder in the class repository, with a plain-language guide so classmates can add their work from a browser.

Where it lives. I first built it inside my own folder, then moved it to the top of the class repository (arko97x/not-localhost-showcase) as `class deployment/`. It belongs to the whole class, so it shouldn't sit under one student's name. Medha's original stays untouched in her folder.

How classmates add their project. Through a step-by-step guide written for non-technical students, covered in the next section.

Running it locally. The project needs a newer Node than some machines have, so it runs through a one-line command that fetches Node 22 just for this site, leaving the computer's setup alone:

```
npx -y node@22 node_modules/vite/bin/vite.js --port=3000
```

Publishing. Changes go live when they're committed and pushed to the repository and the hosted site rebuilds. `class deployment/website-link.txt` holds the public link.

Designing for non-technical classmates

The showcase is only complete when every student can add their own project, so I designed the contributor experience as carefully as the visitor's. Most of the class are designers, not developers, and have never edited a file on GitHub.

I wrote `class deployment/README.md` for that person. GitHub shows it automatically when someone opens the folder, so it's the first thing a student sees.

Design decisions in the guide

Decision	Why
Browser only: no installs, no terminal, no Git commands	Every extra tool is a place to give up
A direct link to the projects folder	Students never have to navigate the repository
One file per student, named after them	"Find your name" is the whole search, and you can't edit anyone else's entry by accident
Five numbered steps with plain headings	Each step is one action, so it's always clear what to do next
A table of only the lines to change, each with its meaning and an example	Students see six familiar things (link, name, description) instead of a wall of code
A before-and-after example	Showing the edit removes the guesswork about format
Three "golden rules" with right and wrong examples	Aimed at the one real way to break the site: a missing quote mark or comma
An explanation of "Propose changes"	Students without access would otherwise think they had failed
A short FAQ and a "please don't change" list	Answers the moments people get stuck, before they have to ask
Friendly tone with visual signposts	Lowers the fear of breaking something

The five steps students follow

1. **Find your file.** Open the projects folder from the link and click the file with your name.
2. **Click the pencil** to edit it.
3. **Change only your lines:** project link, project name, one-line description, category, year and emoji.
4. **Save** with "Commit changes". Without edit access, GitHub offers "Propose changes" instead and the organiser approves it.
5. **See it live:** your number and project name appear on your planet once the site is published.

To test the guide against my own project, I filled in my file the same way: link, the project name NeuroSpace, year 2081 and a one-line description.

Before and after

	Medha's original	Class showcase
Purpose	One author's speculative world	The whole class's work in one place
Projects	13 invented speculative projects	15 real student projects
Where projects are found	Each student's site shared separately	One repository, one website, one link
Content stored in	One 1,340-line code file	One 56-line file per student
Adding a project	Edit code	Edit one file in the browser
Guide for contributors	None	Step-by-step README for non-technical students
Clicking a planet	Camera flies in, full-screen dossier opens	Student's site opens in a new tab
Identifying planets	Hover only	Number and project name on every planet
Sound	Ambient audio, effects, spoken wizard	Silent
Ways to browse	3D only	3D View or List View, one switch
Category filter	3D bottom bar only	Both views, remembered when switching

	Medha's original	Class showcase
Hover card	Same look for all; vanished before it could be clicked	Tinted per planet; stays reachable
Phones	Desktop instructions only	Own wording, compact header, tap to open
Reduced-motion users	No alternative	List View opens automatically
Visitor-made planets	"+ Transmit World", lost on refresh	Removed

Known limitations and next steps

The showcase works end to end; these are the rough edges left.

- [ ] **Card and hint overlap.** On a first desktop visit, the project hover card can cover the "Don't want the 3D view?" hint, since both sit top right. Move the card lower.
- [ ] **Confirm the class site's link.** `website-link.txt` lists neurowalk.netlify.app, which is my own NeuroSpace project. Replace it with the showcase's public address.
- [ ] **Consistent years.** Students write years differently ("2050 CE", "2026", "2026-2050") and one file says "0". Agree a format in the guide.
- [ ] **Filter the planets too.** In 3D View the category filter narrows the bottom bar but leaves every planet lit. Dimming non-matching planets would make the filter visible in the world itself.
- [ ] **Hover details on phones.** Phones skip the hover card and open the project on tap. A tap-to-preview step could show the description first.
- [ ] **Approval load.** Classmates without edit access send changes as requests the organiser must approve. Adding them as collaborators removes that step.